

The past, Brexit, and the future in Northern Ireland: a quasi-experiment

Replication and Extension (Assignment POP77082)

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Outline

- 1 Original Study
- 2 Replication Results
- 3 My Contribution: Extensions

The Original Study: Research Question

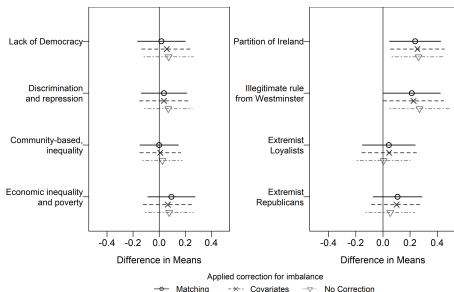
- **Authors:** Godefroidt, Dyrstad & Bakke (2023).
- **Goal:** Test the effect of the Brexit referendum outcome on:
 - ① Perceptions of the causes of *The Troubles*.
 - ② Constitutional preferences for Northern Ireland.
- **Mechanism:** Brexit as a key factor that reactivates memories of political and economic instability.

Exogenous Shock

The referendum (June 23, 2016) took place **during** the fieldwork of the *Post-conflict Attitudes for Peace* (PAP) survey.

- **Control Group:** Surveyed before June 23.
- **Treatment Group:** Surveyed after the "Leave" outcome was known.
- **Method:** Entropy Balancing (EB) to ensure comparability between groups.

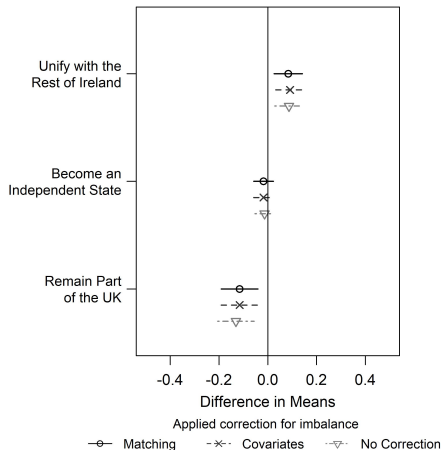
Replication: Perception of Causes (Fig 1)



- Significant increase in the perceived importance of **Westminster rule** and the **partition of Ireland**.
- Robust results across different model specifications (Matching, Covariates, No correction).

Replication: Constitutional Preferences (Fig 2 & 3)

- **Irish Unification:** +9 percentage point increase.
- **Remain in UK:** -13 percentage point drop.
- **Independence:** No significant change.



The Extension: Heterogeneous Effects

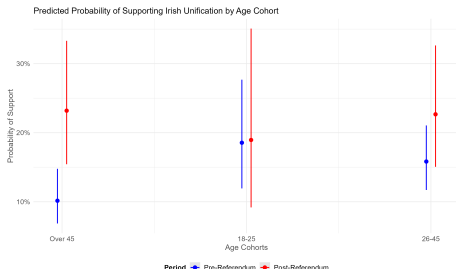
Research Question: Is the Brexit effect uniform or does it vary by demographic profile?

Interaction Models (GLM Logit)

$$\text{Unification} \sim \text{Referendum} \times \text{Moderator} + \text{Controls}$$

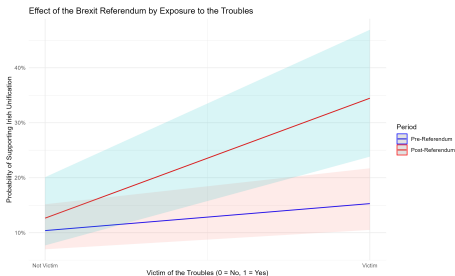
- **Moderator 1:** Age Cohorts (18-25, 26-45, Over 45).
- **Moderator 2:** Exposure to the Troubles (Victims vs Non-victims).
- **Moderator 3:** Gender (Male vs Female).

Extension 1: Age Cohorts



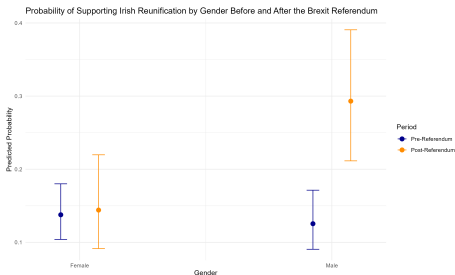
- **Result:** Non-significant interaction.
- **Interpretation:** Brexit acted as a **universal systemic shock**.
- The "jump" is parallel across all cohorts, though the Over 45s show a more precise doubling of support.

Extension 2: Exposure to the Troubles



- **Result:** Significant interaction ($p < 0.05$).
- **Interpretation:** The referendum had a **stronger effect on victims**.
- Personal trauma acts as a catalyst for political change when stability is threatened.

Extension 3: Gender



- **Result:** Significant interaction.
- **Interpretation:** Effect considerably stronger for **men**.
- Possible reasons: Risk aversion in women or stronger link between masculinity and nationalist mobilization.

- The replication confirms the robust impact of the Brexit shock on Northern Irish public opinion.
- **Contribution:** My extension shows that the effect was not socially neutral:
 - It is **gendered** (stronger in men).
 - It is **trauma-sensitive** (stronger in victims).
 - But it is **generationally homogeneous** in its reaction.

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